INDIANS HAVE A LIFE EXPECTANCY of 70.8 years. But the nation's doctors who play a key role in keeping its populace healthy are dying young! In Kerala, in fact, a study of 10,000 doctors (2007-17) found their mean life expectancy to be just 61.75 years. That's in stark contrast with the developed countries, like the US and UK, where doctors in general have a higher life expectancy than the general population. From long working hours to high levels of stress and poor physical health, multiple factors are putting the doctors at risk.

THE ALARMING TREND

Aug. 2024: Dr Anup Roy, 38, died of heart attack while driving his car in Pune

May 2024: Dr Deepak Sharma, 25, died of cardiac arrest while on night duty in a Bhopal hospital

Dec. 2023: Dr Mayank Garg, 26, died of cardiac arrest while travelling in the Delhi Metro

Dec. 2023: Dr Maruthupandian, 30, found dead at his house after allegedly returning from a long shift at a Chennai hospital

Jun. 2023: Cardiologist Dr Gaurav Gandhi, 41, who'd reportedly conducted 16,000 heart surgeries, died of heart attack in Jamnagar

Feb. 2023: Dr SaurabhMathur, 49, a senior orthopaedic surgeon, passed away due to heart attack in Jaipur

Jan. 2023: Dr Sahil Mashal, 30, a senior resident at a Delhi hospital, died of heart attack while on duty

WHY THE DOCTORS ARE AT RISK

Key factors contributing to this silent crisis

POOR PHYSICAL HEALTH

A survey of 240 doctors in South India that was published in the* Indian Journal of Occupational and Environmental Medicine *in 2020 highlighted these concerning numbers

54% Doctors were either overweight or obese

54.5% Doctors reported a low level of physical activity

THE RISK OF CHRONIC DISEASES*

Chronic diseases were found to be the biggest killers in a survey– 'Physician's Mortality Data from 2007 to 2017'–of 10,000 doctors in Kerala

27% Doctors had died due to heart diseases

25% Doctors had died due to cancer

HIGH LEVELS OF STRESS

Two separate studies in the* Indian Journal of Critical Care Medicine *(2015) and* Indian Journal of Psychiatry *(2018) pointed to the toll work takes on their mental health

40% Critical care doctors had moderate to severe stress while working in ICU

30.1% Doctors had depression; 16.7% reported suicidal ideations

WHAT SHOULD BE DONE

- Institutions must ensure doctors work reasonable hours. Working for more than 10 hours a day is detrimental to health; getting 7-8 hours of proper sleep is non-negotiable
- Doctors should adopt healthy lifestyle practices like balanced nutrition, no smoking/ drinking and daily exercise
- They should go for regular health screenings and actively manage conditions like high cholesterol, hypertension and diabetes
- Regular de-stressing through activities like meditation, hobbies or family time will help maintain mental wellbeing and prevent burnout